instruction that I met the PIO to the PM, Sharda Prasad, and handed over the note I had prepared for Kao's perusal, which was unfortunately used for doing just the opposite of what I had suggested. My two subsequent visits to the US and Canada in July 1982 and September 1983 were undertaken as per Kao's suggestion to Suntook and then to Gary Saxena.

It is, however, not clear when Kao came to know about the real nature of the 'final solution' to the Punjab problem. From some of his actions, it appears that he might have come to know of it within a year or so of his appointment as senior advisor as he had started exploring softer solutions for the Punjab problem soon thereafter. His efforts to get Gurudwara Chowk Mehta 'cased' by me, and the aborted SFF-led heliborne operation, are indicative of that.

Kao, however, remained involved with the Punjab decision-making process till the very end and participated in the three meetings with General Vaidya on 25 May, 27 May and 29 May 1984, where the decision to launch Operation Blue Star was taken (next chapter). P.C. Alexander has not mentioned anything about Kao posing questions about the operation at any of the meetings. However, it is my professional judgement, that an experienced person like Kao would not sit quietly during such meetings without asking General Vaidya how General Sundarji's revised plan would help clear a well-fortified Akal Takht without any significant loss of life. Moreover, if DIG BSF, G.S. Pandher (ref. next chapter), could raise such doubts at the meeting called by Maj. Gen. Brar on 3 June, Kao was much better equipped to have asked similar questions of General Vaidya.

It may be relevant here to compare Kao's performance in the pre-March 1977 period as secretary, R&AW, with his post-retirement comeback as senior advisor in August 1981. During his previous tenure, the R&AW achieved major successes within a few years of its creation in September 1968. These included two landmark operations – the liberation of Bangladesh and Sikkim's merger with India – which changed the maps of south Asia and India, respectively. Those achievements built his reputation in India and abroad as a master spy who commanded respect. During that period he had some good friends in P.N. Haksar, principal secretary to the